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Rusty Dedrick

Lyle "Rusty" Dedrick was born in Delevan, New York on July 12, 1918. His family was engaged in farming but both he and his brother Art were attracted to the music business, taking up the trumpet and trombone. Starting in 1938, Rusty toured with Dick Stabile, Red Norvo and Claude Thornhill, eventually establishing himself in the active recording scene in New York City. He has arranged music for numerous ensembles and jazz artists and directed the Jazz Studies Department at the Manhattan School of Music in the 1970's. His recordings include collaborations with Don Elliot and tributes to his favorite jazz soloists, including trumpeter Bunny Berigan.

Rusty was interviewed in Ellenville, New York on June 23, 1998, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in the Catskills, and it's my pleasure to have trumpeter, arranger, composer and educator Lyle "Rusty" Dedrick. Thank you for coming.

RD: My pleasure, very much so.

MR: You are an Upstate-New-York-raised, actually a long line of jazz musicians came from the Catskills.

RD: Yeah, that's true, that's true.

MR: Yeah, a lot of them.

RD: Yes.

MR: When you were, let's say ten, can you recall what the pop music of the day was like, and did it have an effect on you?

RD: To some extent yes. Everyone in my family had, although I grew up on a farm, a little dairy farm outside of Buffalo, everyone in the family played an instrument. My father played the trombone, not the best but the loudest ever, you know in the country bands. I used to love to go and listen to the Saturday night concerts and stuff. That's what kindled my earliest interest. And as far as the pop music, well I think we had a couple of sheets of music, my mother played piano and violin, my brother Art, who is better known, played the trombone way, way back, and I remember a song that we had a song copy of [sings] I'm a dreamer/Aren't we all/Just a dreamer/Aren't we all. And on and on. That would date us, that would pinpoint — and excuse my voice.

MR: Well it's curious because a lot of those tunes, maybe not that one, but some of those tunes became jazz standards later on.

RD: Yeah, right.

MR: I never knew why "Body and Soul" and not—

RD: Well "Body and Soul" was not yet on the scene.

MR: Right. Pre "Body and Soul."

RD: Yeah. Right.

MR: So you had a musical kind of upbringing in your house.

RD: Oh yes. We had the quote Dedrick Family Orchestra unquote. But we played, it was fun.

MR: And your brother took after your father's instrument.

RD: Yes, right. And Art, well he, during the — when the polio thing happened, he became wheelchair bound, so he had to leave. But he had worked with some bands, Vaughn Monroe and that, and he had utilized, now for the first time, his Fredonia degree. And, sorry, teaching in Delevan High School, which is my alma mater. And from then, he realized at that point that there was a dearth of music for the dance band they called in those days, later they called it the stage band. And he started writing music for his own band, and then he started merchandising it via the mail, and then it grew and grew into Kendor Music, which is pretty well known internationally now.

MR: And he thought that there was a market for students to play at that time.

RD: Right. He had a lot of foresight.

MR: Now when he went to Fredonia, and when you went to Fredonia, was jazz allowed?

RD: It was allowed in a limited way I guess, but it wasn't part of the curriculum of course. It had nothing to do with the school itself. But I should mention too that my brother's roommate at Fredonia was Lester Chappell, and the two of them were the founders of Kendor. In fact, Chappie was one year younger than Art and in his senior year I was a freshman so I became his roommate then.

MR: Why did you choose the trumpet?

RD: Well my first instrument was the upright alto horn, because it was available in the family, it was in the house. And I didn't dig it man, you know, um pah, um pah, pah-pah-pah. And I wanted to play the trumpet and I saved my pennies and my first trumpet I bought for $35 and got into it. And then I played trumpet in the high school band and then the way my interests broadened, I was walking down the street in Buffalo as a teenager, in the '30s, and I heard this sound of this trumpet and I couldn't believe it. And I pushed through the crowd to follow the sound, and the source was a crank-up recording machine, a young lady was playing the old 78s. And I said, "What's the name of that?" I thought it was a radio. I said, "What's the name of that orchestra?" She didn't know. She took it off and looked at it. And she said, "That's Louis Armstrong." I said, "I'd like to buy that." And I did. And there you go. That started the whole thing. And when I played the record at home my whole family, who knew nothing of jazz, loved it. So that's how he could communicate.

MR: I guess so. I mean I've heard that story before. So he certainly had a large effect.

RD: Yes.

MR: So your family was, when you said playing in a country band—

RD: A town band.

MR: A town band, okay, so you're playing the Sousa and the marches and the summer concerts.

RD: Exactly right.

MR: They're still around, but that was a big part of the community in those days wasn't it?

RD: Oh yes. On the scene at the time, part of the social fabric of it. It was great.

MR: Was your family affected at all by the depression?

RD: Yes but I didn't feel it. I mean being on a farm where you knew you had a roof and food on the table and all that, of course it was affected to a great degree but I really wasn't aware of it.

MR: Because you were a young — ten or twelve.

RD: Yeah. pre-teen, yeah, right.

MR: So after maybe reading later, you said well I lived through that.

RD: Yeah. Well my wife was a bit younger, she doesn't recall the depression, and we joked about that.

MR: Okay, so Louis Armstrong enters your life.

RD: Changed my life.

MR: Were you curious as to what is it he's doing?

RD: What is what?

MR: What is it that he is doing? Is he reading this music?

RD: Louis?

MR: Yeah. I mean how did your thought process go to try to figure out what it was?

RD: You know I really didn't try to intellectualize it at all, I just knew I heard that sound and it carried so much emotion and expression and everything that it just flipped me out. And then the next big guy was this guy Bunny Berigan. He was actually, you know Louis once said, when asked who his favorite trumpet player was, "My boy is Bunny." And I know why, because Bunny was actually an outgrowth of Louis. Bunny used to say when you go on the road all you need is a toothbrush and some Louis records. Bunny was doing studio work in New York, long before I ever came near New York City of course. And he had a program called "The Saturday Night Swing Session." Leith Stevens was the CBS conductor. And they featured Bunny. And he opened. And this was long before he recorded "I Can't Get Started," which was in 1936, he opened that show with the pick-ups [sings] I've flown around the world— and so forth. And I heard that and that was another thing. I'd like to talk, I know there is time on the session, but briefly about a friend from the hills there, he lived in Springville, New York, his name is Bill Simon. He lives in Florida. Bill Simon later came to New York but not as a professional musician as

I did, but as a writer. He wrote for *Down Beat* in the early stages, and he became the Record of the Month producer for *Reader's Digest*. And when we were kids, literally high school kids, we had a little band, he and I and a couple of others. And we played Saturday night at Morton's Corners in a place where dances were half round and half square. We were the round thank God. And the job started at a certain time, but I would not leave my house until Bunny's show was over. Then I would go to the job.

MR: Well I guess they at least could time you, they knew when you were going to arrive anyway, when Bunny played his last note.

RD: That's right.

MR: When you said the dances were half round and half square, and you played the round part?

RD: Well you know, with the square dances, with the callers and the fiddle and everything. Sure.

MR: But what kind of music were you playing?

RD: Well we played just songs. East of the Sun/West of the Moon or something. You know, whatever songs of the day. And Billy and I used to always argue. I liked Louis, he liked Bix. I liked Louis and Bunny of course, but his boy was Bix. And we traded records back and forth, and it took me a while to really appreciate Bix Beiderbecke. Later, yes. But at that time, you know Louis was so straight ahead you know, that that was for me.

MR: Yeah. He can really grab you. Bix is a little more subtle.

RD: Yes, right.

MR: When was your first attempt, or how did you get into improvising?

RD: Well it's hard to believe right, but I played songs. I'd hear a song on the radio and start to play it, and then noodle around with it as they say. I guess just early ad libbing. I had no formal instruction. Actually in Fredonia, I was only there a little over a year, and the harmony that I was introduced to was not felt in this field you know. It was just from listening.

MR: Playing what your ear told you would work.

RD: Right.

MR: But you went on to — what year were you at Fredonia?

RD: '37. The year '37-'38.

MR: So it became pretty clear to you shortly after that that you wanted to get out and play.

RD: Yeah, right, right.

MR: And was this fella Dick Stabile —

RD: Yeah. Dick Stabile — there was a trumpet player from Buffalo by the name of Joe Gustafaro, who — which, Dick was leaving the band and of course the news got around. And my brother drove me to Pittsburgh to, in essence, audition. All I did was Dick said,

"What do you want to play?" And I said, "Confessing." I played a chorus of "Confessing," and he said all right, but you can't — I was playing cornet — he said, "You can't play on this you've got to get a trumpet. We drove clear back to Buffalo to a music store and got me a trumpet. Went back to Pittsburgh and I joined that band and that's how, through that band, when we were working in Cleveland, Red Norvo's band came. Mr. and Mrs. Swing came in to work the theater. And living at the Allerton Hotel in Cleveland, I used to hang out in the lobby with the guys from Red's band, I loved that band. Dick's band was good. So I had the opportunity to join Red so that was a change in my life too. Because that guy, I mean the learning process, I learned more music from that band. He gave me the opportunity to write. I didn't write. I knew the scales and chords and progressions maybe but he would pay, minimally, I underline, but he'd pay me something to write arrangements for the band. And the arranger pre Rusty Dedrick, was Eddie Sauter. Eddie had left the band, he had played third trumpet with the band and wrote. He was one of my great idols you know.

MR: So you had something to shoot for too, to follow him as an arranger.

RD: Right.

MR: Was there a certain process of writing something and hearing it—

RD: That's it. That's exactly it, yes. That's where Red afforded me that opportunity — to be able to try something, hear it played, and then make some adjustments and so forth. That was priceless.

MR: You can't have a better opportunity than that.

RD: No. And as a teacher, we talk occasionally on the phone, you know he's not well, he's had a stroke and he's incapacitated and he lives in California, but I said you know, "You were my teacher." He doesn't — you know. I just, I love him.

MR: The Swing Era was pretty much at its height right about then.

RD: Yeah, right.

MR: And you guys traveled around mostly by bus or car?

RD: Cars and buses and trains occasionally, but that was a little more costly and Red was never into the money end of it, unfortunately.

MR: You weren't able to set a lot aside for your retirement.

RD: No.

MR: And who would have been thinking about it at that time anyway?

RD: Right. Who cared you know, I just wanted to play.

MR: Yeah, play.

RD: And you know my trumpet mate was Conrad Gozzo. And we were kids together, teenagers, and sitting and playing with him all the time, what more could you ask for?

MR: Yeah. There's actually a little quote from this book *Inside the Big Bands* by a fellow Simon—

RD: George Simon.

MR: He says, "Red came back with another ten piece band in the spring of 1940. This one featured two brilliant young trumpeters, Conrad Gozzo and Rusty Dedrick." He then says, "It produced the same sort of a soft, subtle swing that his 1936 group had," and he went on to say that, "it may have been a little too subtle for what was going on."

RD: It was, yeah, right. It didn't hit you over the head at all. That's why he was never able to get into the big money. But musically it was great.

MR: Did you play mostly dances?

RD: Yes, some concerts, but mostly one nighters, college dates and hotels. Like there used to be — I don't know if they exist today — but the Ben Franklin Hotel in Philadelphia, Huehlbach Hotel in Kansas City. Red and I was talking about that the other day. The hotel had pillars with all mirrors. We were laughing about that.

MR: What did your parents think of this?

RD: They didn't envision me as a traveling musician that's for sure. They wanted me to be a farmer. And my brother Art they wanted to be a Methodist minister. And we failed them.

MR: Say mom and dad, you had the instruments there so what are we going to do?

RD: Yeah. That was your fault.

MR: Did you like being on the road?

RD: I loved parts of it. And when I first left home with the Dick Stabile scene, I was so homesick, but then I outgrew it. You know you'd get to be buddies with the guys you worked with, and they're like a family. I roomed with Conrad for two and a half years. We left Red Norvo's band to go with Claude Thornhill's band. We left together. And then when we left several others, Barry Gallbraith and Ted Goddard and a few others from that great little band left, actually we broke up the band, which for the moment Red didn't like us too well. And we left with Claude because Claude was going into Glen Island and the Schribman office was giving him the same build-up they gave — it didn't have the same result — but Glenn Miller.

MR: Boy I've heard that name a lot, Schribman.

RD: Yes, yes. Sy Schribman and he had a brother. They were big in the New England area.

MR: So if they got behind your big band you had a decent chance.

RD: Yeah. At that time they were carrying microphones up to the stage all the time. And we recorded for Columbia. That was the beginning of Claude getting really into some kind of a public recognition.

MR: It's hard to envision, I think for young people today with the rock & roll bands that tour today and so forth today, and record, that what you guys were doing, that was the scene. That the swing bands were like the rock & roll bands. Is that a fair statement?

RD: I think so. Well when we would work theaters, like you worked the Paramount Theater, you would have like fans standing at the stage door for autographs and stuff. In that sense it was. There were parallels, yeah.

MR: Did you continue writing for all the bands you—

RD: Oh yeah. Then Claude of course was a great, great writer himself. And Gil Evans joined the band. But still Claude gave me a free hand, and he paid more money too. He was more appreciative of the effort that goes into making arrangements than Red.

MR: You copied all the parts yourself?

RD: Oh sure, right.

MR: And not at a computer, either.

RD: No, no, not at all.

MR: In fact I was going to ask you what the average salary of a sideman was in those years.

RD: With Red it was like a low figure and you were lucky to get it. And not that he — it was a financial problem that he could not cope with. That was an old trick, and I should not take too much time on it, but if you worked a week here and then had two days off, they'd change the payday to conform to the next — Now after, with Claude, he had more backing and everything and that was not it. But the salary pre-war I would say ran like $150, something like that a week. Like we had Irving Fazola and Nick Fatool and later Irv —

MR: Cottler?

RD: Right. Thank you. And they were great players working for — You know at one point Billy Butterfield was getting his 802 card, so was Conrad Gozzo and I. And Billy came in and played third trumpet while he was getting his 802 card. And in doing an interview on WKCR they looked at the personnel on different record dates, and he said, "Are you sure that was the trumpet section?" It was.

MR: Yeah the union was very strong wasn't it.

RD: Oh yeah.

MR: What was the minimum age you had to be?

RD: It wasn't a matter of age, at least for me, I had to wait six months to get my card. I left Claude because I was married and my wife was pregnant and I didn't want to travel anymore. I stayed in New York.

MR: So you got into — well Ray McKinley.

RD: Well that was after the war, and I thank Red Norvo for that. Willard Alexander was backing Ray McKinley in a band. Eddie Sauter was the musical director, really wrote the

charts and rehearsed the band and everything. But Ray was a wonderful guy and a great player, and he fronted the band when he could and had another drummer. He was a great guy to work for.

MR: Was this the Glenn Miller band that he was fronting or was it his own band?

RD: No it was his own, but he had been in the Miller band overseas. And in fact when Glenn was lost at sea Ray became the leader of the Glenn Miller Air Force Band.

MR: What did the war years bring for you personally?

RD: Disaster. No. Here again I have to thank Red Norvo for so many things. We were standing in a bar, the Forest Bar used to be a hangout for musicians in New York. I was still with Claude Thornhill. But Red and I were standing at the bar on like maybe a Monday night or something, and I was about to be drafted, and he said — John Mezzi, who had played saxophone with him, he played with Harry James and Raymond Scott and everything, but he played with Red Norvo — John Mezzi is in a band out in Mitchell Field, Long Island, and the band is in the stage of formation. They weren't up to what they called "TO" — table of organization — they were looking for more players. He said, "Why don't you call John Mezzi?" And I did. And I got a letter from the Commanding Officer of the base so that when I went to Whitehall Street to enlist, you know I'm brave now, I enlisted because I knew where I was going. I had this letter in my hand, and it takes all day, you're walking around naked you know. And you finally go up through a line up to a desk where there's this — and I didn't know a sergeant from a general — so I'm sitting there and he's reading a name and saying "Fort Dix." Another name and saying "Fort Dix." And he got to me and he said, "Dedrick" blah blah. And I said, "Uh, uh, uh, excuse me," and I handed him this letter. Well that's thanks to Red Norvo. That got me at Mitchell Field.

MR: So you spent the military years playing.

RD: Not all. Because they started breaking up, this was the Air Force band, an Air Force band. They started disbanding them and reclassifying. And I was reclassified as a carpenter and sent out to Kearns ORD which stands for Overseas Replacement Depot, outside of Salt Lake City, Utah. And I was ready to go, on a shipping list, to the Pacific as a carpenter when the bomb fell. And within two weeks, because I had so much time to my credit, within two weeks I was on my way home. Wow. What a close call.

MR: I guess. Young men at that time, that was just what you did, you went in the service.

RD: Yeah, sure. There was no other thing, yeah.

MR: The only deferment was just physical.

RD: 4F, if you were 4F, yeah. See at that time we were all — now Gozzo, two or three guys from Claude's band got into the Artie Shaw Navy band and they didn't have it easy, they were in the Pacific being shot at you know. But they survived. What a reunion — he

joined Woody's band right after he got out of the Navy, and I joined this McKinley band and we were working the Commodore Hotel and they came in town to play the Paramount. Their band finished early, they call came over where we were, what a reunion.

MR: I guess, wow. Wish to have that on film.

RD: Yeah.

MR: Well after World War II, what happened to swing in your estimation? The big band era?

RD: Well there are so many theories about this, the demise of the big band and everything. I think largely economic, it cost some money. And then the beboppers came along with a smaller group, and probably lower overhead, and they played such interesting things that you can't fault it you know, but I think that that did contribute to the demise of the big band, I don't know. There are many theories, everybody's got their own.

MR: Because — that the audience didn't understand what the bop players were doing so much, or they couldn't dance to it. That's part of it I guess.

RD: I think so. Well yeah, that is one of the theories that killed the bands in that respect. I don't know. Another thing, excuse me, another thing that was a contributing factor was the recording strike and the singers. I mean singers became the thing. Oh — I love Frank Sinatra, but I mean he didn't help the big bands. In a way he helped, but in a way he killed the big bands, because singers became so popular and they didn't need a band except to go in the studio and record or something, or do a show.

MR: It didn't necessarily depend on who was backing them up. It was just a nameless orchestra.

RD: Right if you had a good arrangement with a good conductor and you go and record, or you go and do a concert at Carnegie Hall or something, they didn't have a road band.

MR: So how were you able to carve out your own niche in New York City after?

RD: Okay I got a name, it's the name number one on your list of honorees on the paper you sent me — Dick Hyman.

MR: Oh yeah.

RD: Dick Hyman and I became friends and he — well that's how I did my very first recording under my own name. He took me on a date to play behind a singer. I don't even think I had anything written down. He said well just play it, and then play a solo for eight bars here or something. That was Esoteric Records. They were too. So we did the date and they asked me to do a date under my own name, and that was a ten inch LP in the early '50s. But then we became such friends that he had me on his dates and vice versa, and he's such a talent you know, and such a wonderful person, that that was a turning point as far as I'm concerned, in my getting — opening some doors into the jazz field and the commercial recording studio field and all that.

MR: Yeah, he's been involved in some very interesting projects.

RD: Yeah. What a talent, jeez, great.

MR: It's like all he has to do is decide he wants to play some kind of thing and he can do it.

RD: He can do it all. Yeah.

MR: So the studio scene became pretty healthy in those years in New York.

RD: Yeah. Well there were three networks with the major, even symphony orchestra and a commercial band of 25 or so on staff. And then that all died. Why? I don't really know. It's like the business in the Catskill Mountains. It used to be a thriving, thriving thing and then it died. I can't really understand.

MR: When you got a call to do a recording or a studio date, did you necessarily know who it was going to be for, or what the music was going to be like?

RD: No. I know there was an exception to that that I used to do — Enoch Light had a record — he had two or three different record companies you know. And he was doing these recreations of band hits so called. And they wanted to do "I Can't Get Started." And the date was on a Monday morning at 10 A.M. and I hadn't played over the weekend or anything, and they did call me, the record company, and said Dick has written, he wrote out all the notes, I don't need them I knew them. But they said he wants you to play "I Can't Get Started." That was not the one that's on this record, it was like an actual re-creation of the original, he wrote the chart exactly note for note. And I played the solo note for note. But they said — this is ten o'clock — we don't want you to come in without chops, we want to let you know what you're up against. But most of the time you didn't know. You'd go in, sit down, they'd hand out some charts.

MR: Are there things that stick out in your memory as great sessions, or terrible? That's always a hard question, there's so many of them.

RD: Yeah, it is. There's — I won't say great or not-so-great — but interesting in some respects. Do you know the name Connie Francis?

MR: Sure.

RD: Okay. We used to do her dates, and the contractor is now in Nashville, Danny Davis, he has The Nashville Brass. Well he used to put me on all her dates, and we'd go into the studio in the evening and the trumpet players, there were three trumpets, Charlie Shavers and I and Al Derisi, both deceased unfortunately. But they handed out the first chart, no trumpet parts. They had trombone parts. I know Urbie was sitting in front and she was in the booth, you know, singing to Urbie Green, play it this way. No trumpet parts. So we sat and sat. Handed out the second tune, no trumpet parts. Charlie said, "Let's go get a taste." So we went out the back elevator, went across to the White Rose Bar and had a taste, came back and Danny was at the head of the elevator, fuming. "When I need you

you're not here." Well he was right. So I wouldn't say that was memorable for any special reason other than that.

MR: A learning experience.

RD: Right.

MR: And a lot of these records that you played on, your name was probably never listed.

RD: Most. I mean most. Hundreds, literally hundreds. And then when they did list them, they would list the name only. And there's Eric Goldberg is a local musician here who is a fanatic about collecting records. Hundreds of records he has, and he said, "I see your name on so many records" he said, "you were the busiest fourth trumpet player in New York." There's a reason for that. Most of the really good players would come in, like say their platform was four chairs for the trumpets, if it's Doc Severinsen or Bernie Glow or anything, they wouldn't go in and automatically sit in the middle. Like Jimmy Maxwell. I remember going on a date once and Jimmy Maxwell is already there sitting on the end. I said, "Jimmy, you're in my seat." He said, "Well I'd rather be asked to move up than to be asked to move down."

MR: That's curious.

RD: See it's the opposite of the other philosophy where a lot of guys want to grab the first part. The really good players didn't want to necessarily read off — they did it when they had to because they had to, but that was as far as it went.

MR: That's interesting. Do you have any idea of how many recordings you played on?

RD: Not really. I have a lot that I played on and I have at least maybe a dozen albums that I had done the arranging and so-called leading on, which are under my own name. Some of them are more of a feature thing like this — or I did a lot of recordings of, this record company was interested in doing mostly songwriters. I never really knew much about songwriters or cared much until working for this record company, Monmouth Evergreen Records, we did three twelve inch LPs of Irving Berlin things on the occasion of his eightieth birthday, so you can see how far back it was. And we did Harold Arlen and quite a few others. But those were in a sense commercial, although they were jazz oriented, they had singers and I did the charts and did playing and stuff. And so there are a lot of those kind of things too, as well as just going unrecognized, whatever the word, and just going in and sitting.

MR: Well I have a list out of one of the jazz recording books and it has your eight or nine recordings between 1955 and '65. Those were good years for you.

RD: Yeah, they were, right.

MR: "Rhythm and Winds" on Esoteric, that was your first recording?

RD: Yes, right. That's the very first.

MR: Well it says here a mint condition copy is worth a hundred dollars.

RD: I have one copy. Does it say that really?

MR: It does say that, yeah, I'll show it to you. It's interesting.

RD: Yeah. Dick was on it. I wouldn't do anything without him, it was that kind of a relationship.

MR: How did your association with Don Elliott come about?

RD: Well Riverside Records was a very well respected jazz label, like Keynote, and there were others that go way back. And I recorded for Keynote under my own name and they went bankrupt. Well Riverside didn't go bankrupt. And Dick had a call to do something for them and it was his concept. And he said he'd like to do, that was that thing called "Counterpoint for Six Valves." He'd like to do that and he wrote up some little duets and he picked me and Don Elliott to be the players. And the rhythm section was known at that time as the NBC rhythm section because they were all on staff. That was Mondello, Dick Hyman, Don Lamond and Eddie Safranski. And we just went in and played. That was kind of well received critically. It was a good record.

MR: Did you get any kind of — I'm not sure of the word — from the number of records sold—

RD: Royalties?

MR: Did that make a difference to you or were you just paid from the beginning?

RD: Flat union scale. Royalty you're thinking of.

MR: Right.

RD: No.

MR: So from a financial standpoint, you had a family and so forth, was it tough to make a living in New York or were there a series of years that it was tougher than others?

RD: It was very tough when I first arrived and got my 802 card. I didn't know anybody. I came off the road from playing with name bands. Who cares in New York? And little by little I got to know some people and actually worked my way, opened a few doors. And here again, Dick Hyman was most instrumental in that process for me.

MR: Did you ever need to work a non-music job?

RD: No.

MR: Well that's saying something.

RD: No I never did. I worked a lot of jobs that weren't music in the strict sense.

MR: That weren't musical?

RD: But not disassociated from the so-called business, no.

MR: Well I would imagine being in your position that you took a lot of different kinds of work.

RD: Oh I took anything because—

MR: Bar mitzvahs and all kinds of stuff.

RD: Yes, absolutely. I took anything. I worked with Shep Fields. I got my three months in, in three months you're not allowed to do anything, to get your card, three months on your transfer. The next three months you're allowed to work with permission. And I had some friends from the Army who were working with Shep Fields' band. I had never played that ricky-tick kind of, he called it "rippling rhythm." And they were holding auditions. He was reorganizing his Rippling Rhythm band. They were holding auditions at Nola Studios in New York. So my friend said why don't you come on up? So what would I audition for? The hot seat, right? The jazz player right? Which was nothing. He didn't like me at all. But he said, "While you're here," he said, "why don't you play the first book" you know. And that was the book that had [scats] and the Harmon mute and the bubbles going up and down and the accordion and everything. Perfect. So that's what I did until I got my six months in. I worked it. And I didn't dislike it in the sense that he knew what he wanted. I didn't have to like what he wanted. He knew what he wanted and he knew how to get it.

MR: Well there you go. What didn't he like about your hot playing? Do you know? I mean was it maybe too modern for him?

RD: Well I don't know, I guess it wasn't ricky-tick enough. So he X'd that right away.

MR: He'll put you in the middle seat. You're already there.

RD: That's exactly what happened.

MR: That's great. Now you had a whole other part of your career in the educational field, of course with the arranging but also with Manhattan.

RD: Yeah, I liked that. I started there in '70 and left in '80 because I became 62 and I was eligible for Social Security and I thought oh boy, this is going to be great you know. So I left the job and then I've regretted it many times. It had a lot of advantages. One of them was prior to that, prior to 1970 I used to have rehearsal bands because I liked to write and I had some great players like Arnie Lawrence and on and on in my rehearsal band. And I didn't have that need because I had my own bands to play. And that was an educational experience for me because I could write anything I want and bring it in the next day and play it. It was good.

MR: What did your duties involve?

RD: At school?

MR: Yeah.

RD: Well I taught three or four ensembles, but I used to call it the concert jazz band was the A band sort of, then there was a B band and a couple of smaller groups, and I taught jazz history and appreciation courses and I liked it, it was good. Some of the players that came out of there are still doing great.

MR: Do you have any feeling about the state of jazz education today?

RD: I had a lot of opinions on it. I wrote an article once for an educational publication called *The Instrumentalist*. They asked me to write an article about jazz improvisation and I think I went a little overboard, I said that because of my experience in school where I heard so many young players come in who knew their axes, they could play up a storm, they knew their changes and they could run up and down the changes, but they didn't say anything you know. Some of them did but most of them didn't. And that's what I based the article on, and I said they should listen to Louis, in essence, first. Then learn the changes. Fine.

MR: Well you're not the only one who has said similar things.

RD: Yeah, right.

MR: But in a sense it's nice that education has embraced jazz, and it's become an art form. But on the other hand I'm not sure that it only belongs in a concert hall. We could use those dancing days and the club scene again.

RD: Yes, right, I agree.

MR: But things change, don't they?

RD: Yes. And sometimes irreversibly.

MR: Well let's turn the clock back a little bit and take a listen to this recording, maybe we can get a shot of that cover. One of your heroes.

RD: Oh, yes.

MR: He didn't have a lot of luck as a big band leader, did he?

RD: No. Theoretically he was too nice a way, not a Benny Goodman. We all have had experiences with Benny Goodman you know, most of them not greatly pleasurable. But anyway, that's all, I don't want to go into that.

MR: Right. Okay, so this came about as a tribute and you're on trumpet and Clem DeRosa, Wendell Marshall, Jack Keller and J.L. Porter in quotes.

RD: Yeah, right. He was under contract so they had to —

MR: Who is that?

RD: That's John LaPorta.

MR: Because it said it on this thing.

RD: Well they took license there—

MR: Yeah, right, because it's a re-issue. So the statute of limitations—

RD: Right. His recording contract had expired about 40 years.

MR: Yeah just like Charlie Chan, remember?

RD: Yeah.

[audio interlude]

MR: Was this the tune we wanted to listen to?

Nice lick. You had a beautiful tone.

RD: I'll tell you later why I picked this out of this particular set. There's a reason, not because of my playing, I mean because of a social explanation.

MR: I see you have a vocal on this too.

RD: I sang "I Can't Get Started." Not good, but darn it, Bunny wasn't much of a singer. This is Jack Keller, who lives in Florida. Wendell Marshall, you know played with Duke's band, a great bass player. I loved Hoagie, and I'll go into part of the reasoning why, a great writer, a great songwriter. I wish I had had the chance to do an album of him. You know I did others.

MR: Yeah. It's a challenge writing backgrounds for trumpet and baritone.

RD: Oh, sure, yeah there's not a whole wealth of color.

MR: I think it holds up well.

RD: Thank you. John is a very complex man. Excellent musician. But you know he really made that Berklee.

MR: Wow. Some interesting chords there at the end.

RD: Thank you. The reason for my picking this is not because of the musical content over any of the other things, but, now I hope I can get this straight, my brother-in-law's widow is married to Hoagy Carmichael's stepson. Clear as mud, right? But so we share that. But I loved Hoagy Carmichael, he wrote so many great things, and he never got, I think, the commercial recognition. I mean "Stardust" of course, but so many other tunes that nobody, a lot of people don't know about.

MR: He went all the way back to Bix's days too.

RD: Yeah. He and Bix were like friends. Those must have been great days. I'm a little young for that.

MR: I know.

RD: I actually don't remember many people from that period, but I bet there were some great characters. I knew some of the — like Al Gallodoro and some of the people from that Whiteman band, later on I got to know, and Charlie Margolis was the first trumpet player. Charlie Margolis said, "Bix was terrible" you know. He says, "Well maybe Bix wasn't a great section player. Charlie was a magnificent trumpet player, technically, wonderful. And another parallel example to that, there was a trumpet player from New York by the name of Benny Baker who played first trumpet under Toscanini, and everybody was studying from him at one time. And Doc Severinsen used to take his lesson ahead of me. He'd be in there playing those etudes like he owned them, and I'd go in and struggle. But the point to this whole thing is that Benny Baker also did commercial work as well as playing first trumpet in the orchestra. So he'd do radio, it was radio in those days. And they would give him section players like Bunny was on staff at CBS. He says, "Bunny was terrible."

MR: Oh isn't that interesting. Depends on your outlook, doesn't it.

RD: It sure does. Your point of view.

MR: Well you've written arrangements for Maxine Sullivan and some other singers, Lee Wiley.

RD: Yeah. Wonderful, wonderful. We had lunch with Dick Hyman's wife a couple of years ago at the Mohonk Mountain House or something.

MR: Yeah. Mohonk.

RD: They came up there and called and said could we come over for lunch. And Dick had to leave to go, he was working on another Woody Allen thing you know. So I didn't get to see him that time, but we had lunch with Julia, wait a minute — I lost my—

MR: Well we were talking about Lee Wiley and some of the singers.

RD: Oh yes. She said she and Dick were driving down whatever it is in Paris—

MR: Right, try to pronounce it.

RD: No. And they had the radio on and they were playing, not the Lee Wiley, the other that you mentioned.

MR: Maxine Sullivan.

RD: The Maxine Sullivan thing. And she said, "You were the star of that day." Well that's nice to say, but there was only one trumpet, and I played behind her, and it was fun. Those were musically pleasant. You ask what were some memories, pleasant ones. Those were some. Lee Wiley was at the end of her days you know, and she wrote me the nicest note later thanking me. But she had been a real giant of a singer you know. And she was insecure, and Don Lamond, "Come-on you were great, come-on, don't be—" and encouraging her, and she sang well. I had three horns to work with, Buddy Morrow played trombone and Johnny Mince. The three horns. And usually the same rhythm section: Dick and Milt and, you know, Bucky was on it. Those were pleasant.

MR: Those fellas played on a few records too, didn't they?

RD: Oh — I don't know, you could never count the number of records they played on.

MR: How about personal collections. Have you saved a lot of scores or recordings?

RD: I saved the scores from the Harold Arlen album, because I'm proud of the writing I did for that. That led to something by the way. I got to know John Lewis at school because he was on the Board of Trustees. And when he organized, was a mentor of the American Jazz Orchestra and he did the concerts at Cooper Union, they did a concert based on Harold Arlen and Claude Thornhill, so who was a better natural? And he hired me to conduct, rehearse and conduct. They had — the orchestra was every big name in the city, you know Randy Brecker and on and on. And that was a pleasant thing too. I liked what I wrote for the Harold Arlen album, even though it's not a jazz album. When John called

me I said that's not a jazz album. He said, "We want the tunes." He said, "We're doing Harold Arlen."

MR: How long did you get in the studio to record the typical album?

RD: Well the normal date was a three hour day. Usually you would do I think like this we did four days, I'm not sure. You know they give you a little extra day or something.

MR: Yeah. Appreciate that. Do you write at the piano when you write?

RD: I have no keyboard facility but I have an old Wurlitzer electric piano, it was just perfect for me. I can go over and hit a chord or something and say yes or say no or something. But I haven't gotten into the computer stage, which everybody else — I have a nephew up in Canada who is such a talent, he writes for CBS, Canadian Broadcasting — CBC they call it. And he uses all the new devices. And he's encouraging me to try to get into that.

MR: I don't know. There's something nice about taking a pencil and putting down what's up here.

RD: Yeah.

MR: Do you get a chance to play much these days?

RD: No. Very, very little. I worked the hotels and this you didn't know and now you will know, I worked here, because of a couple of reasons. A good friend of mine and a wonderful saxophone player, Milty Hisler was working here. And the band played a show, that's all, except for a dance set at the end and maybe a couple of tunes at the end. But that was the reason I got started over here. Then one Labor Day the leader came down from Charles Slesky's office, who owns all this stuff, and he said, "No more horns." Well that was it. We had had three or four horns, like I don't know if you know Roswell Rudd, you're going to meet him later anyway. Roswell and I and the saxophone player got X'd and they have never had horns since then. What used to be a band with some horns and another band in the lounge over there, a trio, no more. It's just now a show band itself. It's bass, drums and piano. Now that's pretty much a typical development up here.

MR: It's a shame.

RD: It is.

MR: It's much like, I think for a different reason, but the pit bands that tour with musicals now have shrunk, a lot of it because of electronics.

RD: Yeah sure. They have that in the pit and it's replaced so many live — or at least ostensibly live — musicians.

MR: Yeah. We hope they're alive. Did you bring some other things here you wanted to do?

RD: Yeah, well these are kind of notes that I thought would refresh my memory in case I needed it but I don't think I do. The one thing I wanted to allude to was the fact that with

Red Norvo I was playing a book by Eddie Sauter. And I left and went with Claude, I was playing a book by Gil Evans. And then after the war I would join Ray McKinley playing Eddie Sauter's book. Then I left Ray to go back with Claude, like it was going home, an old home, and it was back to Gil Evans. And you know I played those books, I knew it was great but I never really appreciated it. Such giant writers.

MR: Well especially being a writer yourself, you can appreciate the lines and how they used instruments.

RD: Yes. Gil know I used to say I'm not a composer. Well he was you know. But he'd say I'm not a composer, he'd say Eddie's a composer. He said I'm an orchestrator. He said Eddie could use — he didn't use this expression precisely — but Eddie could use help with his orchestrating, he thought Eddie could improve upon his colors and combinations and everything. But he said Eddie is a composer, I'm not. So it's kind of interesting, not necessarily factual, but— that's about all of it, really.

MR: Well this has been a fascinating conversation.

RD: Wonderful.

MR: And I really appreciate you coming down here.

RD: I appreciate your having me.

MR: I know that your saxophone work too has gotten around, as we can see from this program in Japanese. Very interesting.

RD: That was recorded, that "Modern Art Suite" by the New York Saxophone Quartet. Ray Beckenstein is sort of the leader of that group, a wonderful group of players.

MR: Did your years in the big bands help you figure out what saxophones should and shouldn't do or what you can write for them?

RD: Yes, I think so, yes. Well having heard the instrument so many years by some of the great players, yes. I have some brass quintets that are published and one is in the process right now. I call it "In a Pentatonic Mood." And if you ever notice, the pick-ups to "Sentimental Mood," Duke's, it's a pentatonic scale. So those five notes are the same, and then it's altogether different you know. But that's the way I—

MR: Good lead in.

RD: Yeah.

MR: Well I think from growing up on a farm, and outside Buffalo, you did very well for yourself.

RD: Thank you. I wish my wife thought so. That's — don't quote that. No. Well you know why she's had nothing to do with music and no real interest in that, she's a registered nurse, and a wonderful, wonderful person, but no really understanding of music or the music business. Got great ears. She'll hear something and say oh that's wrong or this is

right or something, but doesn't know why and never really cared or wanted to care about music as a business.

MR: Well on behalf of the college I'd like to thank you for being here today and—

RD: Again, thank you for having me.

MR: Okay. Thanks a lot.